

EYEWITNESS September 19, 1964

The Green Berets in Vietnam

The Green Berets spent their early days in Vietnam dissuading the Montagnards from joining the communist cause. It often took a while for Americans to win the trust of the mountain people. Keeping that trust was also difficult—as 31-year-old Special Forces Captain Vernon Gillespie Jr. found in 1964, when five of the six Montagnard camps in his region staged a mutiny.

The primary mission at the Green Beret camp was twofold: to run reconnaissance missions to interdict the North Vietnamese Army infiltration routes and to rescue captive Montagnards that the Viet Cong were using as laborers and porters at their way stations. The Green Berets brought these people back to a camp at Buon Brieng to deprive the Viet Cong of this labor source.

Tension had been building among the Montagnards at Buon Brieng in late July and early August 1964. On the night before September 19, a rebellion broke out in the camp and the Green Berets were prepared for it. However, the next morning, they discovered rebellion was occurring over a far wider area. Green Beret Captain Vernon Gillespie Jr. told the Montagnards battalion commander that he was taking command of the camp, which meant the Vietnamese Special Forces in the camp were under US protection.

“Any move against the Vietnamese would be considered a move against the US government, and we would fight.”

GREEN BERET CAPTAIN VERNON GILLESPIE JR., FROM *WAR STORIES OF THE GREEN BERETS* BY HANS HALBERSTADT, ZENITH PRESS, 1994